



Cyberbullying and Its Effects in the Virtual World

Nick Mikulski



What is Cyberbullying?

- ◇ A purposeful way to harm an individual through technology.
- ◇ Happens through many digital communication platforms.
- ◇ It can and is more than just insults and threats.
- ◇ Leads to making the internet less safe.
- ◇ A big issue in terms of cybersecurity due to anonymity.

Different Types of Cyberbullying

Harassment

Impersonation of an Individual

Online and Physical Threats

Doxxing

Stalking

53% of U.S teens say cyberbullying is a major issue for people their age (Vogels 2024 p. 23)

Where Can It Happen?

- ◆ Social Media
 - ◆ Instagram & Snapchat tend to be the most popular platforms.
- ◆ Messaging Applications
- ◆ Online Gaming
- ◆ Online Forums
- ◆ Anywhere online that has some form of communication





Impacts of Cyberbullying

- ◆ An increase in levels of stress and anxiety.
- ◆ Depressing thoughts and actions.
- ◆ Social avoidance.
- ◆ Poor academic performance.
- ◆ Negative mental health decline.
- ◆ According to Meyer (2023), “41% of children report that social anxiety is a result of cyberbullying” (p. 29).

Real-World Occurrence

- ◇ Case of Nate Bronstein, 15 years old
- ◇ Was enrolled in a private school in Chicago
- ◇ Bullied to the point of taking his own life
- ◇ His parents were uninformed of what was going on in school
- ◇ According to De Mar (2022), Nates father said, “We need transparency into what they did and didn't do while he was a student there, and after the fact...because if this can be allowed to just be swept under the rug, then it's going to happen again and we're not going to be complicit in that.” (p. 37)

Cybersecurity Concepts

- ◆ Data exposure increases vulnerability.
- ◆ Digital Footprint.
- ◆ Public vs. Private Accounts
- ◆ Protect all your accounts!



Cyberbullying Tracking & Detection

- ◇ AI plays a role in detecting cyberbullying
 - ◇ AI Machine Learning and Algorithms
- ◇ Automation is quicker than human verification.
- ◇ Can be difficult in some cases to detect due to many variables.
 - ◇ Sarcasm
 - ◇ Context
- ◇ Example of machine learning:
 - ◇ Shrestha and Dave (2024) states, “Decision tree: It is easy to understand and implement as it is good for classification and regression. It creates a tree structure where nodes in the tree represent the decision of whether it’s cyberbullying or not” (p. 18).



Legal and Ethical Topics

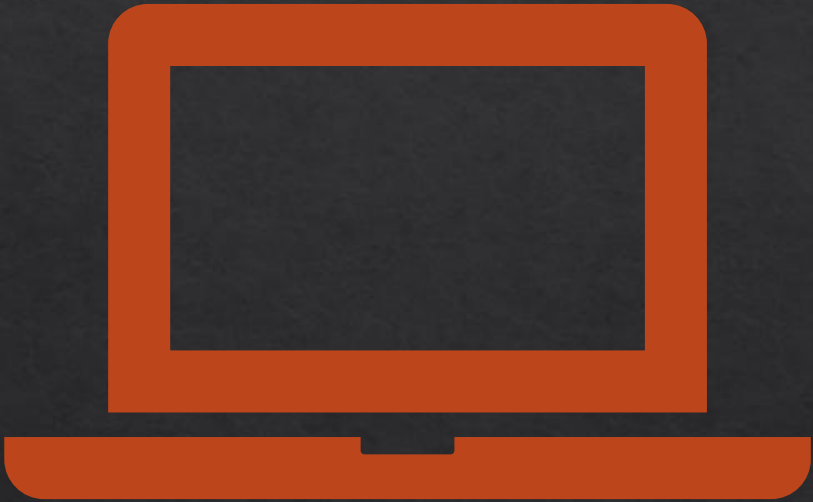
- ◇ Cyberbullying falls under many laws involving stalking, threatening and harassment
- ◇ Ethical concerns:
 - ◇ Anonymity, purposeful hate, misuse of media
- ◇ It is our ethical duty to not engage in harmful behavior
- ◇ Legal consequences:
 - ◇ Active suspensions, civil liability, fines, charges (& juvenile charges)
- ◇ For South Carolina law, McClain (2025) states, “Apart from the potential criminal penalties and school disciplinary options to punish those who cyberbully, it's possible a victim could file a civil lawsuit against them for the emotional, social, or financial harm caused by the offense. For example, a victim of bullying could file a defamation lawsuit against the harasser” (p. 26).

Prevention Methods

- ◆ Protect your account from impersonation with security methods including:
 - ◆ 2FA and MFA.
 - ◆ Strong passwords.
 - ◆ Restricting account privacy.
 - ◆ Block or mute harmful or criticizing users.
 - ◆ Actively talk to trusted persons about any situation happening to you.



Key Takeaways



- ◆ Cyberbullying is a critical important digital safety and cybersecurity issue
- ◆ Occurs across social media, messaging apps, and gaming platforms
- ◆ Causes significant psychological, social, and academic decline
- ◆ Laws and policies provide accountability and protection
- ◆ Everyone plays a role in creating a safer online environment, and it is our duty to keep it that way!

References

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